

P11PHOTO



**POLICEMEN
DISPERSING
PROTEST-
ERS (LEFT);
MIRWAIZ
(BELOW)**

that any political package from Delhi should have included this aspect. So, despite being seen by Delhi as accommodative, Mirwaiz rejected the latest offer after publicly desiring a 'political package' during the visit. Feeling let down that Manmohan did not make any effort to reach out to the people, he said. "It is good to learn that the prime minister is sending peace signals to Pakistan, but that would only work if he sent similar signals to Kashmiris as well."

The army tried to substantiate its status quo on the AFSPA by raising the spectre of a suicide attack during Manmohan's visit and well-placed sources revealed there were even efforts to have the venue of the convocation shifted to the cantonment area. This, however, was turned down by the PMO after getting ground reports from the Home Ministry on the actual situation. Earlier this year, while amend-



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ments to the AFSPA were being readied, the army had raised concerns of a 'hot summer' in terms of militancy in Kashmir. The ploy seemed to have worked as the amendments have not seen the light of day. Such developments, if anything, indicate that the decision-making process on Kashmir may be becoming a function of the army's 'assessment' of the ground situation rather than a seasoned political reading. "The trust deficit is not only

between Delhi and Islamabad as acknowledged by Manmohan. It is as much between Srinagar and Delhi," said a political analyst.

On the economic front, just days ahead of the visit, the Government admitted that only half of the 67 projects drawn up under the Prime Minister's Reconstruction Plan for Jammu and Kashmir have been completed. On November 18, 2004, Manmohan announced a number of plans, including providing basic services, employment generation, relief and rehabilitation to families of militancy victims, but most of this has not happened. The prime minister himself said he was aware of the power crisis plaguing Srinagar and other cities, besides shortages of potable water, roads and ration shops. "I am hopeful that the state Government will look into these complaints. The Centre will extend all possible help in this regard," he said.

In Kashmir, economic development has always played second fiddle to politics. Recently, when renowned Kashmir-born cardiologist Dr Fayaz Shawl returned from the US to work

**NOT JUST MIRWAIZ, BUT
OMAR ABDULLAH AND
MEBOOBA MUFTI ALSO
REITERATED THE DEMAND
FOR DEALING WITH THE ACT.**

on his dream project of setting up a heart research centre in Kashmir, his proposal found no takers. A day before Manmohan's visit, Shawl wound up his project, blaming the state Government for impediments.

In this backdrop, if the previous prime ministerial visits are remembered for the economic packages that yielded no political results in Kashmir, this one stands apart for Manmohan's reluctance to try something new. ■